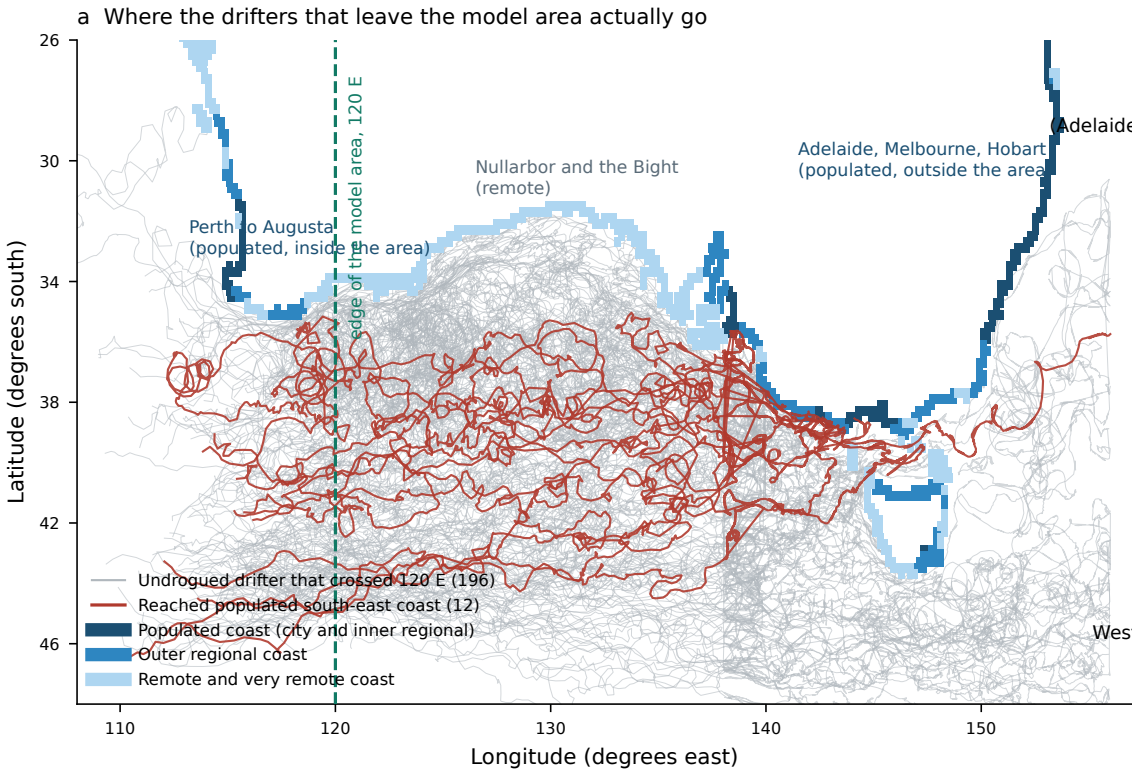
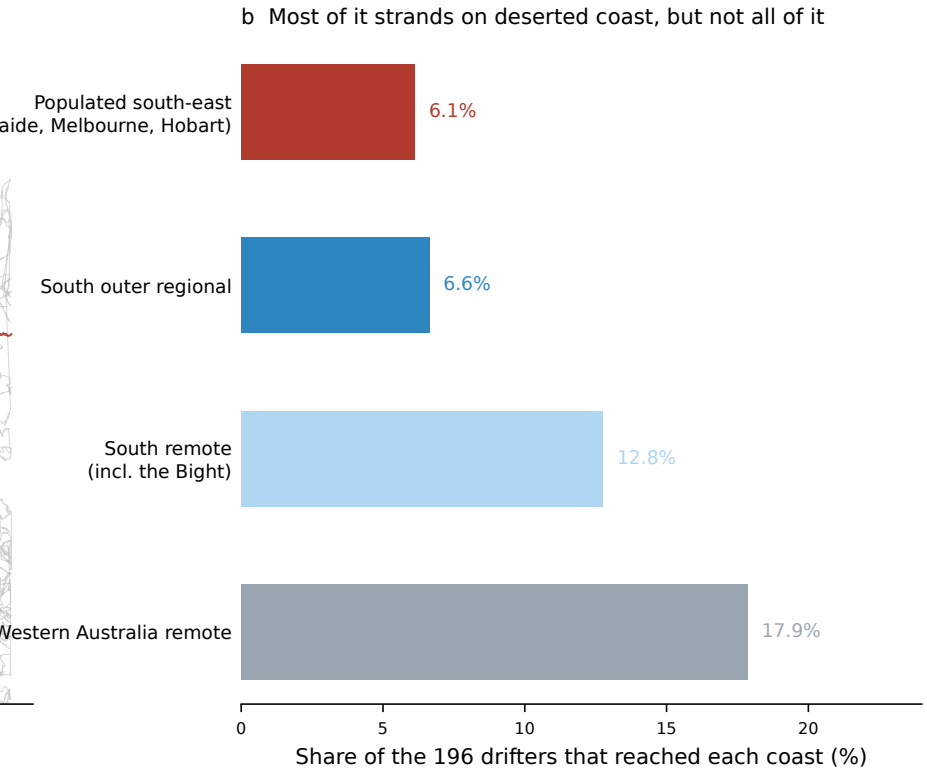
Real drifters show the coast east of 120 E is not all deserted: 12 of 196 reached Adelaide, Melbourne or Hobart





Plain-language note. The model area stops at 120 degrees east. This chart uses real ocean drifters, not the model, to show where floating objects go after they pass that line. Of 196 drifters that have lost their underwater sail and crossed the line between 30 and 45 degrees south, most came ashore on empty coast: the Nullarbor, the Bight and remote Western Australia. But 12 of them reached the coast near Adelaide, Melbourne or Hobart, where many people live. They took a median of 236 days to get there, which is inside the search window. No debris was found on those coasts either, so this part of the area is worth modelling after all.

Technical note. Global Drifter Program 6-hourly quality-controlled drifters (NOAA AOML ERDDAP, drifter_6hour_qc), undrogued rows only (time after drogue_lost_date), two extracts: 20-140 E from the module's existing daily undrogued set and 138-156 E downloaded 15 Oct 2026, joined by drifter identifier. Cohort: first eastward crossing of 120 E between 30 and 45 S, followed for 845 days (8 Mar 2014 to 30 Jun 2016 window length); n = 196 crossings, 1995-2025. Arrival = a position inside the module's own coastal segment boxes (ABS RA 2021 classes), the same proxy the drift model uses; it is not a beaching test. 12 of 196 (6.1 per cent) entered the populated south-east boxes, 12 of the 112 tracked east of 138 E (10.7 per cent); median transit from 120 E 236 days, range 135-813; their crossing latitudes were 38.5-44.9 S, median 41.0 S. CENSORED DOWNWARD: tracking after crossing lasted a median of 170 days, so these are lower bounds. Undrogued drifters carry roughly 1-2 per cent windage, less than high-windage debris, so they are an imperfect analogue. Consequence for the term: at 37-42 S, 41.9 per cent of modelled particles leave the area; at 6.1 per cent that adds 2.6 percentage points of populated arrival to the 4.94 per cent already counted, which multiplies the populated-coast term by about 1.5; on the conditional rate it is about 1.9. Interim, not evidence; not composed.